Social Sciences & Humanities Open 10 (2024) 100916

Contents lists available at ScienceDirect

Social Sciences & Humanities Open

journal homepage: www.sciencedirect.com/journal/social-sciences-and-humanities-open

Regular Article

Educational capital and international mobility: A bourdieusian inquiry into choosing peripheral higher education destination

Hamid Ali Khan Eusafzai

Social Sciences & Humanities Department, School of Arts and Sciences, University of Central Asia, Kyrgyzstan

ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:
Educational capital
International student mobility
Bourdieusian inquiry
Periphery
Higher education
Habitus
International student

Using Bourdieusian theoretical frameworks (field, habitus, and capital) as a lens, this qualitative study explores the motivations of international students who opt for a peripheral destination like Kyrgyzstan for their higher education. The findings underscore the pivotal role of habitus in the decision-making process, operating across layers of aspirational, valuational, avoidance, and compensational habitus. These layers revolve around various fields: the prospective future, home country, and destination country. The aspirational facet of habitus targets a desired positional advantage in future employment. Conversely, the valuational, avoidance, and compensational layers assess the significance of factors and conditions within the respective fields of the home and destination countries, regarding their utility in capital accumulation and conversion for future advantages. This investigation suggests that a deliberate pursuit of employability-oriented self-development propels students towards choosing a peripheral higher education destination like Kyrgyzstan.

1. Introduction

The internationalization of higher education (IoHE), defined as the "integration of international, intercultural, or global dimensions into the goals, functions, and delivery of education" (Knight, 2015, p. 108), has arguably been the most prevalent trend in higher education (HE) in the 21st century. This trend is considered crucial for aligning HE with the demands of a 21st-century knowledge-based global economy (Rumbley et al., 2012; Seeber et al., 2016). Operationalizing IoHE involves various inter-nation activities (Madge et al., 2015) centered around "knowledge transfer, physical mobility, cooperation, and international education and research" (Teichler, 2004, p. 23). Among these activities, international student mobility (ISM) stands out as the most conspicuous and widespread (Teichler, 2017). ISM is broadly defined as "students leaving their country of residence for a period of higher education abroad or to pursue related activity" (International Student Mobility, 2004). The number of such students exceeded 5.3 million in 2017 (UNESCO, 2022) and is projected to reach eight million by 2025 (Dennis, 2018). Due to this substantion number, ISM is often referred to as the 'face of internationalization' (Knight, 2012, p. 21). Singh (2021) considers ISM as one of the key success indicators of IoHE. This form of mobility holds significant academic, economic, and social value for individuals, higher education institutions (HEIs), and governments. For individuals, ISM provides access to international higher education (IHE), fostering knowledge, skills, and competencies that enhance employability and yield various personal, social, and cultural benefits (Brooks & Waters, 2009; Gopinath, 2015; Lillyman & Bennett, 2014; Marginson, 2014). For HEIs and governments, ISM represents a source of revenue generation (Stein & de Andreotti, 2016), contributing around US$300 billion to the global economy in 2016 (Choudaha, 2019). While the individual, institutional, and national value of ISM has sparked competition among major IHE destinations (e.g., USA, UK, Australia, Canada, France, Germany, Netherlands) to attract and retain international students, it has also generated interest in understanding the factors driving students to these destinations (Singh, 2021). Despite extensive research on ISM destination choice, most studies focus on major or emerging destinations, neglecting peripheral destinations (Eusafzai, 2023) due to their

E-mail address: eusafzai.h@gmail.com.

https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ssaho.2024.100916
Received 14 February 2024; Received in revised form 21 March 2024; Accepted 4 April 2024
Available online 9 April 2024
2590-2911/© 2024 The Author(s). Published by Elsevier Ltd. This is an open access article under the CC BY-NC license (http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc/4.0/).

smaller share of students and economic gains. However, with changing global dynamics, peripheral countries like Kyrgyzstan are attracting increasing numbers of international students (Kondakci, 2011), necessitating more research in these areas (see Table 1 and 2). This study aims to fill this gap by exploring, through a Bourdieusian lens and qualitative research approach, the factors influencing international students' choice of Kyrgyzstan as an IHE destination. The central question guiding this research is: Why do international students choose Kyrgyzstan as their IHE destination?

The research focuses on Kyrgyzstan, a Central Asian country lacking global quality standards in higher education despite attracting over 40% (Sabzalieva, 2015) of international student mobility in the region. It aims to uncover why students choose Kyrgyzstan despite its poor reputation. Additionally, it contributes to understanding horizontal mobility, where students move from low-income to similar economic status countries (Rivza & Teichler, 2007). Unlike vertical mobility, this type lacks incentives like immigration prospects or access to higher quality education systems, yet it remains underrepresented in research literature (Brooks & Waters, 2009; Perkins & Neumayer, 2014). The study is crucial for understanding factors influencing student choice in these contexts and holds significance in emerging international higher education hubs (Dennis, 2018), such as Central Asian countries like Uzbekistan and Tajikistan.

2. Research background: international students' choice of destination

Much of the research on international student (IS) decision-making utilizes a push-pull framework (Maringe & Carter, 2007; Mazzarol & Soutar, 2002; McMahon, 1992), which categorizes factors as either pushing students from their home countries (push) or pulling them towards a destination country (pull). Push factors represent disadvantages in the home country that prompt students to seek educational opportunities abroad, while pull factors denote compensating or attractive factors in the destination country (Wilkins & Huisman, 2011). This push-pull binary is commonly employed to understand why IS leave their home countries and what draws them to higher education destinations abroad. These push-pull factors encompass various dimensions, including educational, economic, financial, political, cultural, social, and geographical factors. For instance, educational factors such as deficiencies in the home country higher education system (e.g., limited programme availability, resource constraints, overcrowding, quality of education, limited global exposure, barriers to access) and limited access to higher education at home, along with economic factors such as a lower economic status of the home country, are identified as pushing students to pursue higher education opportunities abroad (McMahon, 1992). On the other hand, destination countries offer educational attractions such as higher quality education, easier access to higher education and admission processes, reputable institutions, and the prestige associated with their educational credentials (James-MacEachern & Yun, 2017; Mazzarol & Soutar, 2002; Shah et al., 2013). Additionally, the better economic standing of a destination country serves as an economic pull factor (Jiani, 2017; McMahon, 1992). Financial considerations also play a significant role in IS decision-making, including the cost of living and studying, availability of grants and/or scholarships, and the potential for future employment in the destination country (Mazzarol & Soutar, 2002; Ahmad & Shah, 2018; S. Z. Ahmad & Buchanan, 2017; S. W. Lee, 2017; Wilkins & Huisman, 2011). Political stability, security, and diplomatic relations between home and destination countries are significant political factors influencing choice-making (S. Z. Ahmad & Hussain, 2017; Wu et al., 2021; S. Z. Ahmad & Buchanan, 2017). Social factors, including the presence of family and social networks, as well as cultural and religious affinity, also play a role in attracting students to a destination (Wu et al., 2021; Lee, 2017; S. Z. Ahmad & Buchanan, 2017). Moreover, cultural and geographical attractions, such as the opportunity to immerse in a new culture and language, and the proximity of the destination to the home country, contribute to the pull factors influencing choice-making (Mazzarol & Soutar, 2002; Wu et al., 2021; Lee, 2017; S. Z. Ahmad & Buchanan, 2017; Jiani, 2017).

Most studies on international student choice-making utilize the push-pull model, criticized for oversimplifying the complex decision process by solely focusing on external factors (Chen, 2017; Wu et al., 2021). This model disregards personal characteristics of decision-makers, leading to a perception of passivity among individuals influenced by external forces. Moreover, it depicts a linear transition from deficiencies in the home country to advantages in the destination, overlooking the dynamic nature of decision-making. This representation fails to capture the complexity of internationalization, which involves multiple global, national, and local players seeking to adapt to changing contexts (Marginson, 2008; Sidhu & Dall'Alba, 2017). International students play a pivotal role in this environment, actively engaging with the process to reshape themselves into global citizens and talents. To understand their deliberate decision-making, an approach integrating external factors with the agency of students is essential. This study explores international student choice-making in peripheral destination countries using Bourdieusian thinking tools, which offer a framework for understanding the interplay between individual and contextual factors (Joy et al., 2018).

Table 1
Number of international students in Central Asian Republics.

Country	Number of International Students Hosted
Kyrgyzstan	36,596
Kazakhstan	40,742
Tajikistan	data not available
Uzbekistan	700
Turkmenistan	153

Source: (UNESCO, 2022)

Table 2
An overview of the geographic distribution of international students in Kyrgyzstan.

Country of Origin	Number of Students	Country of Origin	Number of Students
Kazakhstan	2083	Afghanistan	141
India	10,749	Turkmenistan	121
Tajikistan	2439	Azerbaijan	21
Russian Federation	1844	Nepal	7
Turkey	532	Syria	24
Uzbekistan	14,538	Iran	9
Pakistan	3533		
China	204		

Source: (UNESCO, 2022)

3. Bourdieusian thinking tools: theoretical framework

The Bourdieusian thinking tools utilized in this study are field, capital, and habitus, which have been widely adopted to understand issues related to international student mobility (Dai & Hardy, 2022). Beckler and Forbes (2021) argue that these tools effectively elucidate how external structures influence individuals' life choices and motivation, revealing the intricate interplay between internal and external worlds. Andrews (2021) views these tools as crucial for their explanatory potential in delineating how social agents engage in various social practices to maximize their position.

Field, as conceptualized by Bourdieu, represents an autonomous social microcosm governed by its own laws (Bourdieu & Wacquant, 1992). Individuals occupy hierarchical positions within the field based on their possession of field-specific and legitimate capital (Bourdieu, 1993). Capital, defined by Naidoo (2004), encompasses cultural or

social assets valued within the field, facilitating membership. It exists in various forms, including economic, social, symbolic, and cultural (Turnbull et al., 2019), with Bourdieu introducing additional forms such as embodied, objectified, and institutionalized cultural capital (Bourdieu, 1986).

Habitus, according to Bourdieu, refers to a system of dispositions shaped by individuals' social and cultural experiences (Bourdieu, 1984). It is both deterministic and agentive, evolving over time under social and familial influences. Habitus guides individuals within and towards a field, influencing their actions and strategies for acquiring field-specific capital (Swartz, 2002). This agentive attribute enables individuals to navigate the field and anticipate future opportunities (Bourdieu, 1998).

4. Research methodology

This study, being exploratory in nature, utilized a qualitative research approach. Qualitative inquiry provides the advantage of examining phenomena in their natural contexts, aiming to interpret them based on the significance individuals attribute to them (Denzin & Lincoln, 2018). Ravitch and Carl (2019) advocate for this approach due to its effectiveness in grasping how individuals perceive, engage with, and derive meaning from their surroundings.

Participants were selected through purposive sampling, targeting 113 graduate and undergraduate students deemed most representative of international students coming to Kyrgyzstan for higher education through horizontal mobility (see Table 3). A total of 23 students responded and agreed to participate, considered a robust sample size in qualitative research focused on elucidating specific rather than generalizable information (Creswell & Poth, 2018).

Data collection involved semi-structured interviews (see appendix) lasting 30–45 min, chosen for their depth of exploration (Cohen et al., 2018). Interview questions were informed by the literature review and piloted before implementation. Thematic analysis, following Creswell's (2012) data analysis spiral process, included note-taking during interviews, multiple listenings to recordings, verbatim transcription, sense-making through exploratory reading, coding to break down text data, clustering codes into themes, and manual categorization. Finally, themes were reviewed for relevance to the research question, ensuring rigorous analysis aligned with ethical guidelines outlined by Iphofen and Tolich (2018).

To ensure the trustworthiness and credibility of our data analysis, I employed pivotal strategies including peer debriefing and member checking. In the peer debriefing process, I engaged with more experienced and informed research colleagues to rigorously examine the methodological aspects of our study, specifically focusing on the data collection methods, analysis, and interpretation. This was instrumental in enhancing the study's methodological rigor. Additionally, to minimize researcher bias, we adopted member checking. This involved sharing the interview transcripts with the research participants to verify the accuracy of the transcription. Subsequently, the findings were also presented to the participants to ensure that our interpretations and the identified themes accurately captured the essence of their experiences.

Table 3
Key criteria for the purposeful selection of study participants.

Criterion	Description
International Student	The participant must be a non-citizen or foreign student enrolled in a tertiary education program at a university in Kyrgyzstan.
Field of Study	The participant must be actively enrolled in any higher education program.
Duration of Stay	Participants must have resided in Kyrgyzstan for at least 2 years at the time of the interview.
Geographic Origin	Participants may come from any geographic origin, provided they meet the first three criteria. However, given the study's emphasis on horizontal mobility, participants ideally should originate from developing countries.

Before beginning data collection, this study followed all ethical principles set forth in the British Educational Research Association (BERA) guidelines for educational research (British Educational Research Association [BERA], 2018). Adherence to these principles was manifested by using pseudonyms instead of actual names of the participants, securing the data in encrypted formats accessible only to the researcher, ensuring the participants' anonymity in the findings section of the study, maintaining continuous consent of the participants throughout the study, and ensuring their well-being during data collection and beyond in the member check process. Before the data collection started, the participants were fully briefed on the study's objectives, their voluntary participation, and their right and freedom to withdraw themselves or their data at any point of the study. They were also informed about measures taken to safeguard the confidentiality and anonymity of their data. Informed consent was secured from all participants.

5. Findings

5.1. Reasons for choosing Kyrgyzstan: feel for the game

The research question for this study focused on understanding why participants chose Kyrgyzstan, a peripheral country, as their destination for international higher education (IHE). Through a Bourdieusian lens, these reasons can be seen as a struggle within their home country field, directed towards the destination-country and future-life fields, involving interaction between the participants' habitus and field-related capital. The students' habitus driving their mobility operates at four levels: aspirational, valuational, avoidance, and compensational. Here, I explore how these different levels of habitus, in conjunction with capital and field dynamics, influence the mobility choices of this group of participants.

5.2. Aspirational habitus

The aspirational habitus serves as the starting point of the mobility drive, directing individuals toward their future aspirations. It represents their strategic pursuit of a positional advantage in their future life. Influenced by societal structures, the aspirational habitus emerges as a central driver for mobility decisions, around which other levels of habitus revolve. This level of habitus is evident in students' aspirations for suitable employment post-education. Many expressed the belief that obtaining a higher education qualification would enhance their employability, shaping their aspirations. They desired qualifications that could easily translate into employment opportunities.

> In future, I want to find a good job. I want to work with a good employer in a good position. I wanted an education that can find me a good job and quickly; not like many people who are educated but cannot find a job even after a long time. I don't want to be one of them. (Participant 1)

This excerpt illustrates the students' anticipation of a future struggle in the employment field, where being employed represents an advantage while unemployment signifies a disadvantage. They perceive that possessing a particular form of cultural capital, namely a higher education qualification with broad employability, can mitigate this disadvantage by easily translating into economic capital through employment and its associated financial benefits.

5.3. Valuational habitus

The valuational habitus, triggered by the aspirational habitus, constitutes the second level of mobility-driving disposition. This aspect of habitus is focused on evaluating the worth of home country higher education qualifications in comparison to the participants' aspirations for

future-life field advantages, particularly in terms of employment. This valuation aids in understanding the participants' perception of the value of their home-earned higher education qualifications. Many participants expressed a depreciative view of the value of their home country higher education and its limited utility in achieving their future goals. In Bourdieusian terms, the shortcomings of home country higher education, which motivated the participants to seek education abroad and resemble the push factors of the push-pull paradigm, can be categorized as depreciatory capital. The following provides insights into the participants' perspectives on their home country higher education.

5.3.1. Quality-deficient home HE

The majority of participants compared the quality of higher education in their home country unfavorably to that of the destination-country university. They perceived home country higher education as inferior in quality.

> Universities in my country are not good like the international university that I chose in Kyrgyzstan. No one, if given a choice, wants to study in universities inside the country. Everyone knows they do not offer as good an education as this international university in Kyrgyzstan. (Participant 17)

The participants' comments suggest that they do not see the cultural capital gained from home country higher education qualifications as valuable. Upon further inquiry into why they perceive the local higher education systems as lacking quality, it was revealed that they attribute this deficiency to two main factors: a dated curriculum and non-English medium of instruction. Moreover, their responses indicate that they highly value these factors for their potential to help achieve their future aspirations.

The participants regarded the curriculum as vital for honing their skills and enabling them to thrive in a global setting, thereby improving their employability. However, they noted that the current curriculum in their home country higher education system was outdated and failed to fulfill its intended role of preparing them for the demands of a global environment.

> The curriculum that they teach in Tajik universities is mainly still the same Soviet Union time curriculum. It is nothing practical; only theoretical. No one uses it outside the classroom in life. It is not a good quality curriculum. I want to study what is good for me outside of class, for my life, and for my future. I want to work outside my country and a good curriculum teaches me how to get this work and then how to do it well at the international level. The local curriculum is not this kind. (Participant 22)

This excerpt illustrates the interplay between aspirational habitus, valuational habitus, and capital. Valuational habitus enables participants to assess and determine that the curriculum of their home country higher education is an inadequate form of capital. They conclude that accumulating this capital will not aid them in achieving their aspirations for future positional advantages.

Another aspect of quality considered by the participants was English Medium Instruction (EMI). They expressed a preference for EMI over instruction in local languages, but noted that their home country higher education system lacked EMI. This deficiency was also viewed as indicative of inferior quality. The preference for EMI was tied to their aspirations, as they believed that education through EMI would enhance their English language proficiency. They anticipated that this proficiency would translate into a positional advantage in their future endeavors.

> Not many universities teach in English language in my country. I did not want to study in local language like Russian. I want to improve my English and studying in an English medium university can help me get this goal. This university has this quality. It teaches everything in English. We use English all the time. It made me good in English. (Participant 4)

This excerpt illustrates the students' recognition of the connection between English Medium Instruction (EMI) and proficiency in the English language. Conversely, the subsequent excerpt elucidates their perception of how their English language proficiency relates to their aspirations for future positional advantages.

> If I don't know good English, I'll be working in Russia or Central Asia only. Even in my country, if I want to work in good international organizations, I need to have good English. I know people with good English get a job in these organizations or they go to Europe or America. I want to be there; work with these international organizations or go to other countries. (Participant 16)

Clearly, acquiring proficiency in English is tied to English Medium Instruction (EMI), offering expanded opportunities and advantages in the future. Yet, the local higher education (HE) system fails to provide avenues for self-improvement via a curriculum suited to modern demands or the chance to enhance English proficiency through EMI. Consequently, home-acquired HE qualifications are seen as depreciatory capital, lacking potential for translating into desired employment opportunities in the future.

5.4. Avoidance habitus

While the aspirational habitus revolves around future advantages attainable through an international higher education (IHE) qualification, and the valuational habitus assesses the utility of home-acquired HE qualifications for future goals, another layer termed avoidance habitus is geared towards evading certain constraints in the home country. This habitus aids students in identifying aspects of the home country political and higher education environment that could hinder the acquisition of a valuable HE qualification or lead to obtaining a depreciatory form of this capital. Here are the specifics of these conditions.

5.4.1. Corruption

Participants highlighted corruption within the home country higher education system as a significant constraint. They feared that if not addressed through mobility to a foreign higher education destination, it could lead to the accumulation of depreciatory capital. By studying at international universities abroad, participants believed they could avoid falling victim to the corruption prevalent in local universities.

> I won't choose studying in a good local university. Most of these universities have sons and daughters of the people with influence or government workers. They do not study; they just pay to get good grades. Someone studies and cannot get a good grade, but another does not study at all, pays to a professor, and gets good grade. No one trusts you even if you get good grades from your own hard work. They think you also paid. I don't like this. I want to study in this international university because students get [grades] they study for, and people trust these grades. (Participant 20)

The excerpt reveals the students' recognition of widespread corruption within their home country higher education institutions and their reluctance to be associated with such unethical practices. They perceive corruption as a significant obstacle that could hinder their future prospects. Despite their inability to directly address this issue, they seek to avoid it by pursuing education abroad in institutions known for upholding ethical standards. They fear that even if they achieve academic success through honest means, the stigma of corruption associated with their home country institutions may cast doubt on their achievements.

5.4.2. Cost of education at home

The participants identified the high cost of education and living expenses in their home country as a significant constraint. To circumvent this barrier, they viewed mobility as a viable option. They explained that pursuing higher education at reputable universities in their home country entails higher expenses compared to studying at an international university in Kyrgyzstan. Consequently, they opted to relocate to Kyrgyzstan to pursue their academic endeavors.

> All good universities in my country are in the capital. Studying in them and staying in the capital means you will be spending more than you spend here in this university. This university has all things in one place: classes, dorms, and food. But at capital in my country, I need to search for a room or apartment, then I need to spend on food, and all this makes more than here in this university. (Participant 1)

5.4.3. Security

Security concerns in their home country motivated students, especially Afghan and Kazakh participants, to seek refuge in the peaceful and secure environment of Kyrgyzstan. Afghan students viewed mobility as a way to escape the conflict and chaos prevalent in their homeland.

> The reason I decided to study here is because Kyrgyzstan is a very safe and peaceful country. You know what is going on in Afghanistan. You are not safe at home, on streets and in universities. Your life is not guaranteed. But when this opportunity of studying in Kyrgyzstan came, I thought I can be safe and study in peace as well. (Participant 14)

For Kazakh and Tajik students, the driving force behind their decision to relocate to Kyrgyzstan was not conflict or war, but rather harassment and persecution in their respective home countries. Moving to Kyrgyzstan allowed them to escape the harassment and persecution perpetrated by government authorities in their home countries. One student shared the following experience.

> My brother who was in army refused to follow something by the government. They took him and put him in jail. Then there is always law and order situation in my region. There is always problem between government and local people. Now my mother is so scared. She sent me here for study and asked me not to come back because she thinks they will also take me put me in jail like my brother. (Participant 7)

Therefore, the avoidance habitus centers on three constraining factors originating from the home country: corruption, cost, and security. Participants' aversion to these elements stems from the understanding that they could either obstruct their access to higher education capital entirely (as with security and cost) or lead to the accumulation of stigmatized and depreciatory capital with limited potential for conversion into employment.

5.5. Compensational habitus

The last layer of mobility-oriented habitus, known as compensational habitus, builds upon the aspirational habitus and is directed toward the destination country. This aspect aids in recognizing and justifying the decision to move by identifying compensatory factors present in the destination country that can counterbalance the depreciative capital and drawbacks of the home country-based higher education and environment. These compensations are evaluated for their utility and value in attaining the desired future advantages, and in the analysis, they surfaced as potential gains in the destination country.

5.5.1. Possibilities and gains at the destination

Access Possibilities to HE and Major of Choice. Students were drawn to the destination country by the prospect of easy university entry and the availability of their preferred majors. They explained that opting to study in Kyrgyzstan was motivated by the less competitive nature of university admissions compared to their home country.

> Getting a place in a good university in Pakistan is not easy. There are very few spaces and the competition for these places is very tough. Not everyone can make it to the merit list for admission. One can get admission because they have 0.1 marks more than others but the one with this much less marks will not be able to get a place in a university. You know there is no future without university education in my country. (Participant 5)

Contrary to their experience in their home country, students noted that entry into the international university in Kyrgyzstan was less competitive, thus ensuring they had the opportunity to obtain higher education qualifications. Additionally, they appreciated the freedom to select their preferred major. As one student expressed:

> My goal was to study Computer Sciences. But this chance was not available in my country. There they demand that you study this as a secondary school subject. I did not [study it] because the school I went to did not have [the subject] for the secondary school. I chose to come here because here they did not make any such demand for my choosing Computer Science major. This major is in high demand in jobs in Tajikistan and I can get a good job right after my graduation, I hope. (Participant 10)

The excerpts suggest that both the ease of university access and the ability to choose one's major are highly valued for their potential to facilitate future employment opportunities.

Financial Aid Possibility. The availability of financial aid options at the university was another significant advantage in the destination country. This opportunity held immense value for students who lacked the financial means to afford their higher education qualification.

> When I saw that I can get financial aid, I decided to apply for study in this university. Financial aid was very important for me and my family. It was a great help and it made studying in this international university possible for me. Otherwise, it was not possible for me and my family to afford my study in a university. Our income is not that much. (Participant 9)

In summary, the possibility-related factors present at the destination can be seen as facilitating conditions that assure students of access and subsequent accumulation of the desired cultural capital in the form of an international higher education qualification.

5.5.2. Gains at the destination

In addition to compensating for the limitations of the home country and personal constraints of the students, the international university at the destination also promised certain gains. While the conditions at the destination facilitated access to and acquisition of cultural capital for future employment advantages, these gains ensured the appreciation and convertibility of this capital through the acquisition of valued dispositions.

One significant gain was derived from diversity. Despite perceiving the home country education system as deficient in quality, participants held a contrasting belief about the higher education quality at the international university in the destination country. This perception emerged as a driving factor for mobility. The data revealed that the presence of international faculty and a diverse student body were two key factors associated with quality. The following excerpt exemplifies the participants' views on the diversity of faculty members:

> When I knew that there is a good number of international faculty in the university, not just the local or regional faculty, like the teachers coming from other countries outside Central Asia, I really wanted to join this university. It is a sign of quality. These teachers bring another view to class. It was an opportunity for me to learn something new about the world. It also means teaching in class is in

English and it will improve my English skills also. So, I thought two benefits with international teachers: a new view of things and English. (Participant 12)

Evidently, the students perceived international faculty as a source of acquiring intellectual and linguistic advantages, which can be viewed as a form of cultural capital. Firstly, they saw their interaction with the faculty as an opportunity to access diverse viewpoints of the world, thereby expanding their perspective and understanding of global issues. Secondly, since these interactions were conducted in English, students believed it would contribute to the development of their English language proficiency.

The participants also recognized the value of diversity within the student population at the university and anticipated various benefits from this diversity.

I liked the idea of having students from different countries and cultures. It is an opportunity to make friends with them and learn about their place, culture, and language. I live with a dormmate from another country. I learnt and discovered so many things from this experience. I now have a totally different idea of the world and many things in my person also changed. I realised I can live and like people who are different from me. It will be helpful for me in future when I live and work in an international situation. (Participant 22)

Therefore, it can be inferred that the participants perceive the social network on campus as a means of acquiring social capital, assessing its value based on its potential to contribute to their desired future positional advantage. The existence of this social capital provides the participants with certain dispositional enhancements that they believe will aid them in reaching their future objectives.

Gains from the Curriculum. Similarly, the gains from the curriculum implemented at the university stand in stark contrast to the curriculum offered at local universities in their home countries.

The curriculum is great. It is not like what I studied in my school. In school, all I learnt was about my own country, its people, culture, history, and geography. In this curriculum, we learn about the world and a lot of linking of the world to our local [context]. All the time now we talk global and think global. It is now as if I know the world and not just my little country. (Participant 2)

The curriculum at the international university broadens the intellectual horizons of the students, offering a broader canvas compared to the more localized knowledge provided by their home universities.

6. Discussion

This study sought to uncover the motivations driving international students to pursue higher education in a peripheral destination. Given the scarcity of research on international student mobility in such contexts, this study aims to fill this gap. The findings of this study can be interpreted in two main ways.

Interpreting the motivations behind international students' decision to pursue education in Kyrgyzstan through the lens of Bourdieusian thinking tools, habitus emerges as a key driving force for this mobility (see Fig. 1). Habitus dictates the patterns of action, thought, and identity formation, influencing individuals' choices and behaviors (Maton, 2008). It can be understood as the students' intuitive understanding of the rules and requirements of the game they are playing, which includes considerations of future advantages, necessary capital, and the comparative value of capital in both their home and destination countries (Bourdieu, 1990). This habitus operates across various layers, targetting the home-country, destination-country, and future fields. In this case of mobility, the habitus reflects the students' intentional focus on achieving specific goals and outcomes. This intentionality stems from the students' aspirations to acquire capital that can provide them acompetitional edge in the future. This intentionality guides the

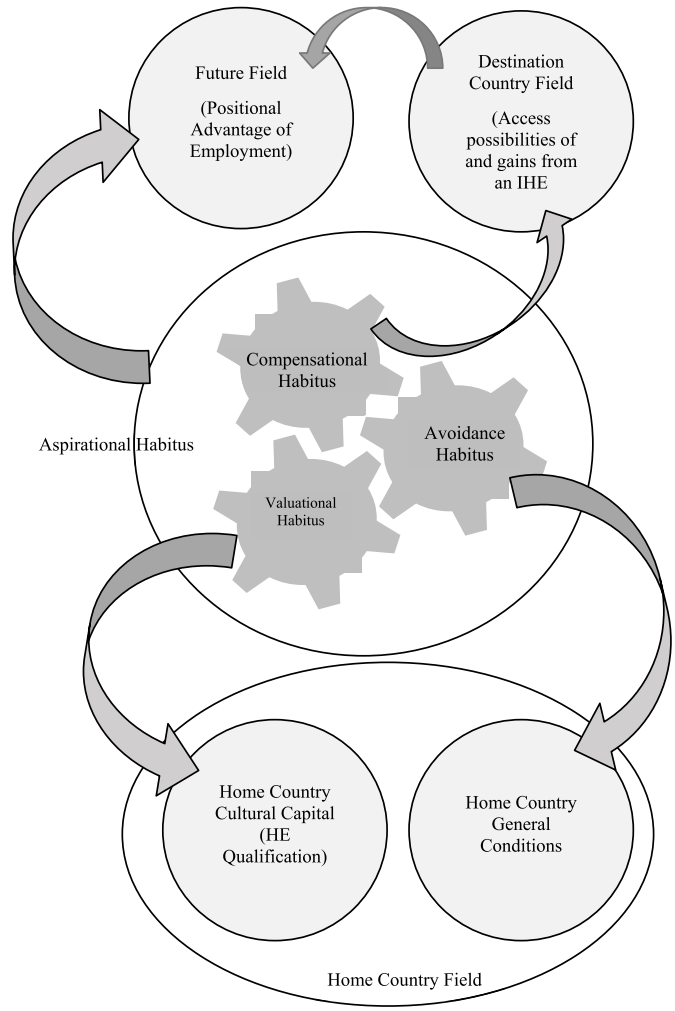

Fig. 1. Habitus, capital & field coaction in the students' choice of Kyrgyzstan as an IHE destination.

identification of the necessary capital and dispositions required to fulfill these aspirations, as well as the strategies to attain them. These determinative aspects of intentionality then manifest in the students' decision-making process regarding a peripheral destination. The students have a clear objective for their future: securing good employment. Recognizing that attaining this goal requires cultural capital in the form of a higher education qualification, the students are motivated to pursue educational opportunities abroad. This awareness initiates the activation of the valuational, avoidance, and compensational layers of their aspirational habitus.

The valuational layer of the aspirational habitus is centered on the deficiencies perceived in the home country higher education system, particularly related to the outdated curriculum and lack of English-medium instruction (EMI). Viewed in light of their future aspirations and the capital necessary for achieving a positional advantage in the future field, the participants perceive home country higher education as inadequate. When compared with these aspirations, the possession of this capital, with its deficiencies, does not guarantee the desired position in the future field.

The avoidance layer of habitus also revolves around factors within the home country but operates at a macro level, particularly concerning the higher education system. It assesses these factors based on their impact on the future value of the capital acquired through a local higher education qualification (such as the reputation for corruption in the system) and their influence on access to this cultural capital. The avoidance habitus concludes that the local higher education

qualification holds little value upon conversion and perceives factors like cost and security as hindrances to accessing even this diminished form of capital.

The compensational layer of habitus, stemming from the aspirational habitus perspective, is centered on destination country factors and their potential to facilitate the attainment of future aspirations. The facilitation pertains to access-enabling factors such as ease of entry and financial aid, which make it possible to acquire the valuable and convertible cultural capital of an international higher education qualification. The instrumentality pertains to the dispositional gains derived from the presence of social capital, such as diversity among faculty and students, and cultural capital, such as a modern curriculum, on the campus. These dispositional gains hold the promise of enhancing the value and convertibility of the IHE qualification capital for future advantages. As per Bourdieusian terms, engaging with the cultural capital present at the destination offers the symbolic capital of "the acquisition of a reputation for competence and an image of respectability and honourability that are easily converted into [a better future] position" (Bourdieu, 1984, p. 29).

In the context of ISM to Kyrgyzstan, the interplay among multiple fields (home country, destination country, and future), habitus, and capital in this case study can be succinctly summarized by a corollary: ISM for IHE in the periphery is primarily steered by the intrinsic motivation for academic and personal development gains, with the caveat that these gains are translatable into desired future employment. Additionally, the presence of factors facilitating access and the higher symbolic value associated with foreign HE credentials compared to those from the home country are crucial determinants in the decision-making process. In summary, the participants' decision to choose Kyrgyzstan as their IHE destination was driven by a "goal-oriented focus" (Pham, 2018, p. 178). Their short-term intrinsic goal was centered on personal growth and development, while their long-term extrinsic goal revolved around obtaining IHE credentials with the potential for greater future employment opportunities (Zhang & Zhang, 2017).

At a basic level of analysis, the reasons for selecting Kyrgyzstan align with the traditional push-pull paradigm, wherein the decision is influenced by limitations in the home country and perceived strengths in the destination country. The limitations in the home country propel students to seek opportunities elsewhere, while the strengths of the destination country pull them towards it. The identified limitations in their home country include an outdated curriculum in the local higher education system, the absence of English as a medium of instruction, corruption in universities, higher costs, and security concerns. Similarly, the attractions at the destination include a modern curriculum, English as a medium of instruction, financial aid opportunities, easy access to education, and a diverse campus environment. The findings at this traditional level corroborate the findings of existing research on IS choice-making conducted in both core and semi-peripheral destination contexts (James-MacEachern & Yun, 2017; Mazzarol & Soutar, 2002; McMahon, 1992; Shah et al., 2013). This confirmation suggests that the motivations and attractions for mobility in IHE are consistent across all three contexts: the core, the semi-periphery, and the periphery. However, there are notable differences. While some existing studies, such as McMahon and Mazzarol & Soutar, highlight national or country-level attractions like destination nation culture, climate, and economic status, these factors were not prominent in the current study. Instead, the drives and attractions identified in this case study predominantly revolve around micro-level factors (Jiani, 2017) related to the students' personal characteristics or the institutions they choose to attend, rather than national or country-level considerations. This observation suggests a characteristic feature of South-to-South mobility. It implies that horizontal mobility is primarily motivated by individual and institutional factors, given the parity between home and destination countries at the national level. For instance, in this study, the social, cultural, political, and economic profiles of the destination country (Kyrgyzstan) do not offer any significant advantages or attractions over the participants' home countries (Afghanistan, Kazakhstan, Pakistan, Tajikistan, Syria, Kenya).

7. Conclusion

This research aimed to uncover the motivations behind international students (IS) choosing Kyrgyzstan as their international higher education (IHE) destination, shedding light on IS mobility dynamics within the peripheral context of Kyrgyzstan using Bourdieusian analytical tools. Adopting a qualitative research approach within the interpretive research paradigm, this study offers theoretical and practical insights. The theoretical contribution lies in addressing the imbalance in existing literature, which predominantly focuses on IS mobility in the global North, neglecting the perspectives from the global South. By employing Bourdieu's theoretical framework, the study emphasizes the agency of individuals in the decision-making process, contrasting with the passive push-pull model.

Practically, the findings highlight the significance of individual aspirations and motives, especially in South-to-South IS mobility within peripheral countries. In the absence of country-level attractions, recruitment strategies should cater to individual needs and align with the international aspects of the local HE systems. This entails enhancing the international dimension of the curriculum, emphasizing employability skills for a global context, utilizing English as the medium of instruction, and promoting diversity on campus. Marketing efforts should center on addressing individual expectations related to future employability and demonstrating how the international aspects of the destination country align with these aspirations.

On the whole, the study uniquely explored international student mobility in the non-traditional context of Kyrgyzstan, significantly contributing to the literature by shedding light on under-researched destinations. The diversity of our participant sample, encompassing various nationalities, academic levels, and fields of study, enriches our findings, providing a comprehensive understanding of students' motivations and experiences. Rigorous data analysis techniques, including multiple coding rounds, peer debriefing, and member check, underpin the credibility and validity of our research. Additionally, the practical implications of the study's findings offer valuable insights for recruitment strategies and policy-making in higher education within peripheral contexts, enhancing the study's relevance and impact.

However, the study is not without its limitations. The choice of a single peripheral country, Kyrgyzstan, while providing in-depth insights, may limit the generalizability of our findings to other contexts. Additionally, the qualitative nature of our study, focusing on a purposively selected sample of international students, means our results reflect the experiences and perceptions of a specific group rather than a broader population. While our rigorous thematic analysis ensured a comprehensive understanding of participants' motivations and experiences, the subjective interpretation of qualitative data could influence the conclusions drawn. These limitations highlight areas for future research, encouraging the exploration of international student mobility in a wider range of peripheral destinations and employing mixed-methods approaches to enhance generalizability and depth.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Hamid Ali Khan Eusafzai: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Visualization, Validation, Supervision, Software, Resources, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Funding acquisition, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization.

Declaration of competing interest

I declare that I have no conflicts of interest regarding the publication of this research article, "Educational Capital and International Mobility:

A Bourdieusian Inquiry into Choosing Peripheral Higher Education Destination." I have no financial or personal relationships with other people or organizations that could inappropriately influence my work or the interpretation of my findings.

Appendix

Semi-Structured Interview Protocol

1. Would you like to introduce yourself please?
2. What is your major?
3. Where are you from?
4. Do you have any previous experience of studying outside your country?
5. What led you to select Kyrgyzstan for your higher education journey?
6. What made you conclude that studying in Kyrgyzstan offered a better or different educational opportunity compared to other options available to you?
7. Could you explain if any specific career goals or future aspirations led you to choose Kyrgyzstan for your studies?
8. What made you conclude that Kyrgyzstan offered a better or comparable educational opportunity than your home country or other alternatives?
9. What were the undesirable factors or conditions in other well-known study locations that influenced your decision to study in Kyrgyzstan?
10. Can you describe the advantages you foresee your Kyrgyzstani education providing in addressing global employment challenges?
11. Would you like to add anything else to what you have already told me?

References

Ahmad, S. Z., & Buchanan, F. R. (2017). Motivation factors in students decision to study at international branch campuses in Malaysia. *Studies in Higher Education, 42*(4), 1–18. https://doi.org/10.1080/03075079.2015.1067604

Ahmad, S. Z., & Hussain, M. (2017). The analytic hierarchy process of the decision-making factors of African students in obtaining higher education in the United Arab Emirates. *Compare: A Journal of Comparative and International Education, 47*(2), 163–176. https://doi.org/10.1080/03057925.2016.1171703

Ahmad, A. B., & Shah, M. (2018). International students' choice to study in China: An exploratory study. *Tertiary Education and Management*, 1–13. https://doi.org/10.1080/13583883.2018.1458247

Andrews, T. (2021). Bourdieu's theory of practice and the OECD PISA global competence framework. *Journal of Research in International Education, 20*(2), 154–170. https://doi.org/10.1177/14752409211032525

Beckler, L. E., & Forbes, D. (2021). Bourdieu's contribution to psychoanalytic thinking in the context of research. *Journal of Social Work Practice, 35*(2), 205–217. https://doi.org/10.1080/02650533.2020.1764916

Bourdieu, P. (1984). *Distinction: A social critique of the judgement of taste*. Routledge.

Bourdieu, P. (1986). The forms of capital. In *Handbook of theory and research for the sociology of education* (pp. 241–258). https://www.marxists.org/reference/subject/philosophy/works/fr/bourdieu-forms-capital.htm.

Bourdieu, P. (1990). *The logic of practice*. Polity Press.

Bourdieu, P. (1993). Field of power, literacy field and habitus. In *The field of cultural production*. Polity Press.

Bourdieu, P. (1998). The New capital. In *Practical reason: On the theory of action* (pp. 19–33). Stanford University Press.

Bourdieu, P., & Wacquant, L. (1992). The logic of field. In *An invitation to reflexive sociology* (pp. 94–114). Polity Press.

British Educational Research Association [BERA]. (2018). Ethical guidelines for educational research, fourth edition. In *Ethical guidelines for educational research* (4th ed.) https://www.bera.ac.uk/publication/ethical-guidelines-for-educational-research-2018.

Brooks, R., & Waters, J. (2009). International higher education and the mobility of UK students. *Journal of Research in International Education, 8*(2), 191–209. https://doi.org/10.1177/1475240909105204

Chen, J. M. (2017). Three levels of push-pull dynamics among Chinese international students' decision to study abroad in the Canadian context. *Journal of International Students, 7*(1), 113–135. http://jistudents.org/.

Choudaha, R. (2019). Beyond $300 billion: The global impact of international students | studyportals. https://studyportals.com/intelligence/global-impact-of-international-students/.

Cohen, L., Manion, L., & Morrison, K. (2018). *Research methods in education* (8th ed.). Routledge.

Creswell, J. (2012). Educational research: Planning, conducting, and evaluating quantitative and qualitative research. *Educational Research*. https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9781107415324.004

Creswell, J., & Poth, C. (2018). *Qualitative inquiry and research design: Choosing among five approaches (Fourth)*. Sage Publications.

Dai, K., & Hardy, I. (2022). Language for learning? International students' doctoral writing practices in China. *Journal of Multilingual and Multicultural Development*, 1–14. https://doi.org/10.1080/01434632.2022.2089154

Dennis, M. (2018). *A new age in international student mobility*. June 8. University World News http://www.universityworldnews.com/article.php?story=20180605103256399.

Denzin, N. K., & Lincoln, Y. S. (2018). Introduction: The discipline and practice of qualitative research. In N. Denzin, & Y. Lincoln (Eds.), *The Sage handbook of qualitative research (Fifth* (pp. 29–86). SAGE Publications, Inc. https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9781107415324.004.

Eusafzai, H. A. K. (2023). Inhabiting the peripheries: A bourdieusian exploration of international students' encounters in Kyrgyzstan. *Frontiers in Education, 8*. https://doi.org/10.3389/feduc.2023.1291357

Gopinath, D. (2015). Characterizing Indian students pursuing global higher education: A conceptual framework of pathways to internationalization. *Journal of Studies in International Education, 19*(3), 283–305. https://doi.org/10.1177/1028315314563783

International student mobility. (2004). *Higher Education in Europe, 2*(4–5). https://doi.org/10.1080/0379772770020410

Iphofen, R., & Tolich, M. (2018). The SAGE handbook of qualitative research ethics. https://doi.org/10.4135/9781526435446.

James-MacEachern, M., & Yun, D. (2017). Exploring factors influencing international students' decision to choose a higher education institution. *International Journal of Educational Management, 31*(3), 343–363. https://doi.org/10.1108/IJEM-11-2015-0158

Jiani, M. A. (2017). Why and how international students choose Mainland China as a higher education study abroad destination. *Higher Education, 74*(4), 563–579. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10734-016-0066-0

Joy, S., Game, A. M., & Toshniwal, I. G. (2018). Applying bourdieu's capital-field-habitus framework to migrant careers: Taking stock and adding a transnational perspective. *International Journal of Human Resource Management*, 1–24. https://doi.org/10.1080/09585192.2018.1454490

Knight, J. (2012). Student mobility and internationalization: Trends and tribulations. *Research in Comparative and International Education, 7*(1), 20–33. https://doi.org/10.2304/rcie.2012.7.1.20

Knight, J. (2015). International universities: Misunderstanding and emerging models? *Journal of Studies in International Education, 19*(2), 107–121. https://doi.org/10.1177/1028315315572899

Kondakci, Y. (2011). Student mobility reviewed: Attraction and satisfaction of international students in Turkey. *Higher Education, 62*(5), 573–592. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10734-011-9406-2

Lee, S. W. (2017). Circulating East to east: Understanding the push–pull factors of Chinese students studying in korea. *Journal of Studies in International Education, 21*(2), 170–190. https://doi.org/10.1177/1028315317697540

Lillyman, S., & Bennett, C. (2014). Providing a positive learning experience for international students studying at UK universities: A literature review. *Journal of Research in International Education, 13*(1), 63–75. https://doi.org/10.1177/1475240914529859

Madge, C., Raghuram, P., & Noxolo, P. (2015). Conceptualizing international education: From international student to international study. *Progress in Human Geography, 39*(6), 681–701. https://doi.org/10.1177/0309132514526442

Marginson, S. (2008). Global field and global imagining: Bourdieu and worldwide higher education. *British Journal of Sociology of Education, 29*(3), 303–315. https://doi.org/10.1080/01425690801966386

Marginson, S. (2014). Student self-formation in international education. *Journal of Studies in International Education, 18*(1), 6–22. https://doi.org/10.1177/1028315313513036

Maringe, F., & Carter, S. (2007). International students' motivations for studying in UK HE, Insights into the choice and decision making of African students. *International Journal of Educational Management, 21*(6), 459–475. https://doi.org/10.1108/09513540710780000

Maton, K. (2008). Habitus. In M. Grenfell (Ed.), *Pierre Bourdieu: Key concepts (second* (pp. 48–64). Routledge/Taylor & Francis Group.

Mazzarol, T., & Soutar, G. N. (2002). "Push-pull" factors influencing international student destination choice. *International Journal of Educational Management, 16*(2), 82–90. https://doi.org/10.1108/09513540210418403

McMahon, M. E. (1992). Higher education in a world market, an historical look at the global context of international study. *Higher Education, 24*(4), 465–482. https://doi.org/10.1007/BF00137243

Naidoo, R. (2004). Fields and institutional strategy: Bourdieu on the relationship between higher education, inequality and society. *British Journal of Sociology of Education, 25*(4), 457–471. https://doi.org/10.1080/0142569042000236952

Perkins, R., & Neumayer, E. (2014). Geographies of educational mobilities: Exploring the uneven flows of international students. *The Geographical Journal, 180*(3), 246–259. https://doi.org/10.1111/geoj.12045

Pham, L. (2018). International students' aspirations to contribute to socioeconomic development in vietnam. In L. T. Tran, & S. Marginson (Eds.), *Internationalisation in Vietnamese higher education* (pp. 177–199). Springer. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-319-78492-2_10.

Ravitch, S. M., & Carl, N. M. (2019). *Qualitative research: Bridging the conceptual, theoretical, and methodological*. Sage Publications.

Rivza, B., & Teichler, U. (2007). The changing role of student mobility. *Higher Education Policy, 20*(4), 457–475. https://doi.org/10.1057/palgrave.hep.8300163

Rumbley, L., Altbach, P., & Reisberg, L. (2012). Internationalization within the higher education context. In D. Deardorff, H. de Wit, J. J. D. Heyl, & T. Adams (Eds.), *The SAGE handbook of international higher education* (pp. 3–26). SAGE Publications Ltd. https://doi.org/10.4135/9781452218397.n1.

Sabzalieva, E. (2015). Challenges in contemporary higher education in Kyrgyzstan, Central Asia. *Perspectives: Policy and Practice in Higher Education, 19*(2), 49–55. https://doi.org/10.1080/13603108.2015.1011727

Seeber, M., Cattaneo, M., Huisman, J., & Paleari, S. (2016). Why do higher education institutions internationalize? An investigation of the multilevel determinants of internationalization rationales. *Higher Education, 72*(5), 685–702. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10734-015-9971-x

Shah, M., Sid Nair, C., & Bennett, L. (2013). Factors influencing student choice to study at private higher education institutions. *Quality Assurance in Education, 21*(4), 402–416. https://doi.org/10.1108/QAE-04-2012-0019

Sidhu, R., & Dall'Alba, G. (2017). 'A strategy of distinction' unfolds: Unsettling the undergraduate outbound mobility experience. *British Journal of Sociology of Education, 38*(4), 468–484. https://doi.org/10.1080/01425692.2015.1131143

Singh, J. K. N. (2021). Enhancing international student experience: Pre-support support services provided to postgraduate international students in a Malaysian research university. *International Journal of Inclusive Education*, 1–15. https://doi.org/10.1080/13603116.2021.1879953

Stein, S., & de Andreotti, V. O. (2016). Cash, competition, or charity: International students and the global imaginary. *Higher Education, 72*(2), 225–239. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10734-015-9949-8

Swartz, D. (2002). The sociology of habit: The perspective of pierre Bourdieu. *OTJR: Occupation, Participation and Health, 22*(1_suppl), 61S–69S. https://doi.org/10.1177/153944920202208108

Teichler, U. (2004). The changing debate on internationalisation of higher education. *Higher Education, 48*(1), 5–26. https://doi.org/10.2307/4151528

Teichler, U. (2017). Internationalisation trends in higher education and the changing role of international student mobility. *Journal of International Mobility, 5*(1), 177. https://doi.org/10.3917/jim.005.0179

Turnbull, S. M., Locke, K., Vanholsbeeck, F., & O'Neale, D. R. J. (2019). Bourdieu, networks, and movements: Using the concepts of habitus, field and capital to understand a network analysis of gender differences in undergraduate physics. *PLoS One, 14*(9), Article e0222357. https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0222357

UNESCO. (2022). Global flow of tertiary-level students. *Global Flow of Tertiary-Level Students*. http://uis.unesco.org/en/uis-student-flow.

Wilkins, S., & Huisman, J. (2011). International student destination choice: The influence of home campus experience on the decision to consider branch campuses. *Journal of Marketing for Higher Education, 21*(1), 61–83. https://doi.org/10.1080/08841241.2011.573592

Wu, M.-Y., Zhai, J., Wall, G., & Li, Q.-C. (2021). Understanding international students' motivations to pursue higher education in mainland China. *Educational Review, 73*(5), 580–596. https://doi.org/10.1080/00131911.2019.1662772

Zhang, K. C., & Zhang, A. (2017). Dare to dream: Personal values, life goals, and international students in New Zealand. *Journal of Religion and Health, 56*(5), 1503–1514. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10943-016-0307-7